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ST. LOUIS POST-DISPATCH

Frisch Outlasted The Incredible Rajah In Every Way

Fifty years ago this week, Frank Frisch, the understated left-hopping gnat on the spot marked "X" at old Sportsman's Park in his first game at second base for the Cardinals, reached down for a ground ball and — as the Washington Post's Shirley Povich best described the baseball embarrassment — the Fordham Flash fell nothing.

The Redbirds, who had won their first world championship in 1926 under the departed slugger Rogers Hornsby, were playing their St. Louis neighbors and rivals, the Browns, in the annual spring exhibition. The Browns' great first baseman, George Sisler, just had hit a potential double-play ball right through the chunky legs of the sticky Frisch. And as two brown-legged runners crossed the plate, Frisch stood out there, hands on knees and head lowered, as he heard the chant rise from the stands:

"We want Hornsby... we want Hornsby..."

Before he died four years ago at nearly 77, a decade after Hornsby played his last game at a Chicago race track, Frisch could tell with amusement about that first St. Louis test as successor to the dinged Hornsby, who had been dealt to the New York Giants in a shock-trading trade.

"You've heard, I'm sure, about the reverberations that resulted the previous December when Sam Braden, who owned the Cardinals, signed me to the Giants the long-covered slugger who had AVERAGED .400 for five seasons through 1925 and then put the frosting on the city's half-century celebration of the

bob broeg
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National League with the Redbirds' first pennant. If the Rajah had wanted to run for mayor then, the question merely would have been on which ticket. (No, Rog, not the daily double.)

Trouble was, the tough-talking Hornsby, though a handsome neoclassic, was even more stubborn than Braden, the one-time poor kid from New York's lower East Side. Braden had struck it rich — parlaying a modest World's Fair popcorn concession with an automobile grease-monkey business — to become a well-to-do young baseball fan who permitted his enthusiasm to get him investing heavily in the rag-tag Redbirds.

Snaping Sam, the elbow-bending barbershop quartet man, had formed a masterful check-and-balance combination with his personal antithesis, business manager-field manager Branch Rickey, a former catcher and graduate lawyer who had come up in 1920 with the better baseball mousetrap, the farm system by which the impoverished could keep pace with the wealthy clubs. Finally, figuring that the pain-stinging, evangelistic Rickey was a better bet than bench boss Braden, he hired B. R. of his field foreman duties on Memorial Day 1925 and kicked him up

stairs as general manager. Angry, Rickey resigned, by Julius Frest, that he didn't want that \$30,000 stock in the Cardinals anymore, and Braden arranged the financing for Hornsby to buy it.

So when Rog rudely told Sam what the employer could do with an exhibition game Hornsby wanted canceled down the pennant stretch in '26 — the Post-Dispatch's J. Roy Stockton called it "an utterly impossible disposition" — a breach developed. And when Hornsby failed to show proper servility to Rickey, too, and then wanted a three-year contract with a pay hike from \$30,000 to \$50,000, Braden's daily made a counter offer he knew the outspun lioness wolf from the Lone Star State would reject: One year.

One ugly word led to another and Braden, who had turned down \$250,000 cash for Hornsby from New York when the Redbirds' financial capitol was bare, picked up the phone and told the Giants they could have baseball's greatest right-handed hitter for Frisch and that young first baseman who hadn't had too good a year, Bill Terry. But you didn't want Rickey, did you? So Charley Stoneham's cat or John McGraw?

Flash In Doghouse

Frisch had been McGraw's boy, a star at second base and third, for four pennant-winning ball clubs, hitting .300 in all World Series, but the Flash had got into Mr. McGraw's doghouse by jumping ship at St. Louis in 1926, unable

to tolerate any longer the abuse the Giants' mercurial manager traditionally heaped on his captain when angry at an error or a strikeout.

So Braden could have Frisch and a lesser player, either of two pitchers, Jack Scott or Jimmy Ryan, Braden-Rickey chose Ring.

Determined to show up McGraw and to ease his plights here, the 35-year-old Flash worked out at winter at Lake Placid, Braden, meanwhile, was subjected to indignities from an irate St. Louis citizenry. His fashionable West End home and Pierce-Arrow automobile agency were frequented in black crepe. The Chamber of Commerce denounced Frisch's Sam by resolution, and one St. Louis sports editor bawled in print that he'd never cover another Cardinal ball game.

Briefly, Redbird players cold-shouldered Frisch in spring training at their Avon Park (Fla.) training camp, but it was hard to stay angry at the articulate extrovert who had been born with a silver spoon in his mouth, but talked as roughly as if he had cut his teeth on a brass cuspidor.

No Hornsby as a hitter — after all, how many men ever averaged .358 for a career? — Frisch still was tough as the clutch, a switcher who thrived on pressure in tight World Series, standing head-on, sliding roughed handfirst and fielding spectacularly with diving stops. A Hall of Famer, like The Rajah, The Flash who became pilot light of the Gas House Gang as manager (1933-34) never was better than in 1927, that first year wearing the uniform of the Redbirds.

Hornsby, meanwhile, had a strange career after he was traded to the Giants. He hit .365 at the Polo Grounds, but was dealt to Boston for catcher Shanty Hogan and outfielder Jimmy Walsh because he had not been sufficiently civil to owner St. Louis or the town's lackey, traveling secretary Jim Tierney.

Travels Of The Rajah

At Boston, hitting .367 against the wind off the Charles River, Hornsby became player-manager of a 1929 pennant. Rog told kindly owner Judge Emil Fuchs of the under-financier Braves that the Judge couldn't pass up the five players and \$200,000 the Braves offered.

With the Cubs, Hornsby did what came naturally for the sturdy right-handed hitter who could do everything except go back on a pop fly. He hit .360 and the Cubs won the 29 pennant under manager Joe McCarthy. In 1931, The Rajah succeeded McCarthy as manager of the Cubs and was canned in August of '32, just before the Cubs rallied to win a pennant for Charley O'Connell.

Hornsby, who had missed most of the 1930 season with a broken nose, was bothered by best spurs. The speed at 37 was gone along with the money he had gambled away as he returned to the



YES, THEY DID: Rogers Hornsby (left) and Frank Frisch. Hall of Fame second basemen traded for each other 50 years ago, ultimately did play together briefly with the Cardinals in 1933. Here, they're shown in spring training.

Redbirds in 1931, primarily to pinch-hit. With Charley Gelfert out with a gunshot wound to the leg, they temporarily tried to move Frisch to shortstop and to play Hornsby at second base. But it didn't work, leading to the deal with Cincinnati for Leo Durocher.

Said Frisch before his fatal automobile accident in 1973, "I wasn't sure-handed enough at shortstop and didn't go to my left as well as to my right. Rog couldn't go to his right. So we practically camped on top of each other at second base."

Just after Frisch was named manager of the Cardinals in July 1934, the perceptive Rickey, who could have convinced the Browns that Hornsby was just the man to boost their box office as manager, if not the poor Browns didn't even draw 90,000 the ENTIRE 1935 season at home.

The Rajah bounced around the bushes from 1937 until the younger Bill Veck brought him back to St. Louis as manager briefly in 1952, but that didn't last, either, nor did a short milk shake as manager at Cincinnati.

When he died at 87 in 1963, a result of a blood clot following surgery for cataracts in his eyes, he was remembered for the movies or anything except the racing farm show. Hornsby had little left from a lifetime of investing in fast women and slow horses.

Frisch, though his top playing salary was \$25,000 to Hornsby's \$30,000, outlasted his long-time rival in every direction, including financially and in longevity — 11 seasons. It was after the Frisch hit .337 in 1927, stole 48 bases and set a still-existing record for chances handled by an infielder (107), that Braden said

A Dirty Trick

"The way we drew Frisch in '27, I was convinced that it was the team that was important — the place in the race," said Signe Sam, rewarded with nine pennants and six world championships from 1916-46 even though he and Rickey sold many players who came back to cost them pennants.

Hornsby wasn't really quite so cold or unfeeling as it seemed to men who played for him or to fans who contributed to an automobile he gambled away. When, for instance, New York newspapers in 1928 ran a daily base contrasting second-base successor Andy Cohen's statistics, as both Manhattan and St. Louis papers had run a daily comparison of Hornsby and Frisch in '27, The Rajah thumped the Big Town press.

"You're playing a dirty trick on the old (Cohen)," said Hornsby, calling his shot. "I'll leave the poor — far be

hind." Frisch, not exactly a shrinking violet, either, could fall back on his record, too, just as he did 50 years ago this week when he reached down and felt nothing as that double-play ball went through his legs, giving the Browns two first-inning runs and that crowd a chance to chant derisively. "We want Hornsby... we want Hornsby..."

Cynically, to elicit a sympathetic chuckle in his retelling of that embarrassing St. Louis debut a half-century ago, Frank Frisch would omit this postscript.

The Cardinals beat the Browns that April afternoon 50 years ago, 5-3, on an eight-inning record for chances handled by an infielder (107), that Braden said

IT WAS AN HONOR. The Billiken Faceoff Club honored four members of the St. Louis University hockey team last night. From left to right are: Brian Rol (most improved

player), Kent Jackson (110 per cent award), Wayne Ormsen (most valuable player), and Grant Googien (freshman of the year). (Post-Dispatch Photo by Wayne Crosslin)

Kuhn Gives Approval To Cuban Invitation

NEW YORK, April 12 (AP) — Baseball Commissioner Bowie Kuhn has given his preliminary approval to an invitation from Cuban Premier Fidel Castro to send a major league all-star baseball team to Cuba, Kuhn's office said yesterday.

Bob Witz, director of information for the commissioner's office, said the invitation was relayed to Kuhn by Senator George McGovern (Dem.) South Dakota, who accompanied a South Dakota basketball team on a tour of Cuba last week.

"He (Kuhn) did talk to Senator McGovern and told him that we're continuing our effort to send an all-star team to play in Cuba," said Witz. "He could probably do so either after the World Series (in October) or next spring."

However, Witz said it was too early to consider any such goodwill tour an accomplished fact.

"It would seem, with the events of the day, that it probably moved a step closer," he said, "but in our minds it would be premature to be saying the commissioner had accepted the invitation and to make it sound like the tour definitely will happen."

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